Poem: Remains

On another occasion, we got sent out
to tackle looters raiding a bank.
And one of them legs it up the road,
probably armed, possibly not.

Well myself and somebody else and somebody else
are all of the same mind,
so all three of us open fire.
Three of a kind all letting fly, and I swear

I see every round as it rips through his life –
I see broad daylight on the other side.
So we've hit this looter a dozen times
and he's there on the ground, sort of inside out,

pain itself, the image of agony.
One of my mates goes by
and tosses his guts back into his body.
Then he's carted off in the back of a lorry.

End of story, except not really.
His blood-shadow stays on the street, and out on patrol
I walk right over it week after week.
Then I'm home on leave. But I blink

and he bursts again through the doors of the bank.
Sleep, and he's probably armed, and possibly not.
Dream, and he's torn apart by a dozen rounds.
And the drink and the drugs won't flush him out –

he's here in my head when I close my eyes,
dug in behind enemy lines,
not left for dead in some distant, sun-stunned, sand-smothered land
or six-feet-under in desert sand,

but near to the knuckle, here and now,
his bloody life in my bloody hands.

Simon Armitage

Anecdotal language, *matter of fact tone, suggests this is one of many events.*

Colloquialism, *slang 'legs it'=run off. Used to give realistic tone to the voice of the speaker.*

Aside *'possibly not' undermines severity of the statement, if he was not armed should he have been shot? He has the power to decide.*

Analogy, *soldiers described as cards in Poker, a game of luck. Emphasis that everything about this was just chance.*

Graphic Hyperbole *used to demonstrate the lack of glory or honour in this killing, it is not pretty but still very matter of fact..*

Dehumanised *'looter' 'sort of inside out' makes the victim appear more of an object than what was moments ago a living breathing person.*

Colloquialism, *'mate' almost makes this appear like a night out with the lads, like a social event.*

The nature of what is happening, a violent killing is ***juxtaposed*** *to the relaxed way he talks about the event.*

Metaphor *for the memory of the man and events. Blood connotes death, shadow connoting lingering memory.*

Repetition *from the start to show that this is the thought replaying in his mind and he is racked with guilt. He now feels powerless.*

Cliché *'flush' common term to get rid of something unwanted, this is no longer a matter of war but everyday life.*

Analogy, *describes the memory like a hostile soldier in his mind, where he cannot get him.*

Sibilance, *smothered, six, sand: gives the impression of a sinister dream/nightmare like state.*

Pun, *bitter/dark humour bloody meaning covered in blood but also an expression of anger/hate. The soldier is at conflict with this dead man, but more with his own mind. Ends the poem with a sense of despair and open ended., no resolution.*

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look up PTSD (Post traumatic stress disorder), what are some of the stories and experiences of sufferers, how has it changed their life and how can this be related to the speaker in the poem?

-Go through the poem and highlight the words and phrases which help show the speakers tone.

Context:

The poem is written from the perspective of a soldier stationed in Iraq or Afghanistan (or any warzone really). They are on patrol and fire on some bank robbers. One of the looters appeared to possibly have a gun so they open fire. The rest of the poem is looking at the fact the solider, even long after this event, cannot leave the memory behind and carries this dead man with him in his mind.

Post traumatic stress and mental illness is very common in soldiers who struggle to come to terms with some part of their duty, normally a horrific memory of killing or being in danger which gives them nightmares and panic attacks as well as depression and sometimes suicidal tendencies.

Simon Armitage is a famous UK poet who is known for being very direct in his work. His recent poems have looked at the experiences of war and soldiers.

Themes:

The poem is originally set in a warzone and naturally looks at conflict in a direct way. However it also looks heavily at the after effects of conflict and the long term effects it has on the people involved. Power is partly shown in this as well, firstly the soldiers power over life and death but later the power over their own memory and experiences. Mental health and morality are also key in this.

Structure: The poem is written in 8 stanzas, the last of which is a couplet which leaves the poem on a dramatic end note. It does not rhyme and the poem is a monologue, using very conversational **asides** and **syntax** to structure the sentences into a very conversational tone "end of story, not really". There is also a lot of **enjambment** and **caesura** used to emphasises the natural speech patterns of the speaker. Another key factor in this poem is the use of **colloquialism** (slang) and **personal pronouns** to give it a sense of **realism,** "One of my mates,".

There is a loose set of rhymes in the poem, often internal and used to give an almost childish aspect to the horror of the warzone. It perhaps suggests how numb this soldier is to what is happening.

Numb:

The speaker in the poem (the soldier) appears to be numb to the horror of the experience of war, most of the horrific images of death and killing are juxtaposed to the casual nature of the way the soldier speaks, using slang and clichés. In part this reflects a conflict in himself, the way he sees these events and how they affect him, but also his way of trying to maintain control, by trivialising the whole experience.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem explores the events in a soldiers life which in turn trigger PTSD, it is worth noting the memory hurts him more than the event itself.	*-The poem looks at the experiences of a soldier at war and how he suffers from the memory.*
*-The **colloquial** nature of the speakers voice is used to create a sense of **heightened realism** to the piece.*	*-The poem uses a lot of slang to show the tone of the speaker.*
-The poet suggests a conflict in the speakers mind, an avoidance of the reality of what happened which haunts him.	*-The way he talks about what happened and the actual content of what happened don't seem to match up.*

Space for your notes: